and two years later moved further westwards and erected a boundary marker at the Karakoram Pass.

This was indeed surprising for, in 1865, William Henry Johnson, who had earlier been involved in the survey of Kashmir and Western Himalayas, had surveyed the Ladakh-Tibet border. As part of the Trigonometrical Survey of India, he was to draw up the elusive Ladakh-Tibet border extending from Demchok in the south to the 18,000-foot-high Karakoram Pass in the north. Johnson took the Kuen Lun Mountains and not the Karakorams as the natural boundary and thus included the barren Aksai Chin desert into the boundaries of Kashmir.



Leaving the Aksai Chin to the north, the boundary then drops south from the Changchenmo Valley to Spiti that is today a part of Himachal Pradesh. This line passes through Pangong Tso, Chushul and Demchok, all of whom have seen minor boundary disputes over the ages. The entire frontage for the western section is over 1,610 kilometres long; and of the nearly 39,000 square kilometres that is under dispute, the bulk of the territory is today under Chinese control.